



Mixed fortunes: (Left to right) **1.** Satwiksairaj Rankireddy & Chirag Shetty won bronze in the 2025 BWF World Championships, their second in the tournament after the 2022 edition. **2 & 3.** Minakshi Hooda (48kg gold) and Mirabai Chanu (48kg silver) are among the Indian Worlds medallists whose disciplines won't feature in LA 2028. **4.** None of India's Paris medallists won a medal in their respective 2025 World Championship events, including double Olympic medallist Manu Bhaker. GETTYIMAGES

WORLD RESULTS DON'T TRACK PERFECTLY WITH OLYMPIC PERFORMANCES. INDIA WON FEWER 2017 WORLD MEDALS THAN IN TOKYO OLYMPICS

won silver in the women's 48kg category at the Weightlifting World Championships. However, with that weight class cut from the Olympic programme, she has said she will move up to the 53kg class, which will feature in LA.

There have been a number of near misses as well. The Indian women's recurve archery team made it to its first-ever bronze medal match at the Archery World Championships before losing in the final set to heavyweights South Korea. Javelin thrower Sachin Yadav finished fourth in his debut at the World Athletics Championships in Tokyo.

Furthermore, the Indian men's hockey team, which has won Olympic medals at the last two editions, hasn't had the chance to compete at a World Cup so far, with the next edition scheduled only for next year.

While India's sportspersons have performed better compared to previous Olympic cycles, there is a caveat.

Three years out from the Los Angeles Olympics is a long way to go. And of the three years in an Olympic cycle, the year immediately after the Olympic Games is usually the one with the least at stake.

"The year after the Olympics is usually when you see a lot of athletes take time to do things they might have put on hold during the Olympic cycle. They might have exams or personal goals," says Ronak Pandit, high performance director of the Indian shooting team.

India's top-ranked male recurve archer Dhiraj Bommadevara, for example, has reworked the draw strength of his bow — a significant adjustment in a technical sport. Simranpreet Kaur, who won gold in the 25m pistol competition at the Shooting World Cup Final, missed out on selection for the World Championships as she was preparing for her third-year college exams.

That said, the results in 2025 still matter. It's the season when new coaches were tested, training systems reset and new athletes entered senior pipelines. They are useful, at the very least, in assessing the immediate health of Indian sport.

However, results at World Championships don't track perfectly with performances at the Olympics. Although India won fewer medals at the World Championships in 2017, it ended up winning more medals in Tokyo (seven) compared to the five in